ELITE FOUR CAPITAL

Poll Aggregation and Pollster Credibility

Methodology for the Polling Desk. This paper explains how the desk blends the polls, scores the pollsters, and turns the poll-minus-market gap into trades.

1. Abstract

The Polling Desk keeps a weighted average of the national 2028 Democratic primary polls. It sets this average against the live prediction-market prices. This paper documents each weight in the pipeline. It gives special attention to one question: how the desk assigns credibility to each pollster and each poll. The method follows the published work of FiveThirtyEight (G. Elliott Morris's 2024 pollster-ratings paper and the polling-average method) and Nate Silver's primary forecasting. Where the desk simplifies, the paper says so.

2. Why an average at all

A single poll of 500 people has a sampling margin of error near plus or minus 4.4 points. The true error is larger. Nonsampling error does not show in the reported margin. It comes from frame coverage, weighting, question wording, and differential response. Silver's 2024 review puts the average general-election polling bias near 4 points, even in aggregate. An average across firms cancels the random error of each firm. A weighted average cancels it faster. 538 found that POLLSCORE-weighted averages are less biased than averages weighted by recency and size alone. Aggregation is the minimum standard, not a luxury.

3. Credibility of the pollster

538 rates pollsters on two axes. The first axis is accuracy. 538 measures each past poll's error and bias against the election result. It adjusts for how hard the race was to poll (Excess Error). It compares the firm to other firms in the same race (Relative Excess Error). It shrinks the result toward a prior that uses transparency-organization membership and partisan clientele (Predictive Error). It penalizes herding, which is a poll that sits suspiciously close to the average. The second axis is transparency. 538 asks ten yes/no disclosure questions per poll: question wording, crosstabs, weighting variables and targets, sample selection, sponsor disclosure, and acknowledgment of nonsampling error. It combines the two axes by Pareto optimality into a 0.5-to-3.0 star rating.

The desk cannot run that full pipeline, because it needs 538's poll database from 1998 to today. Instead, the desk gives each firm an approximate star rating. It anchors the rating to 538's published ratings and reasoning. It converts stars to weight as w = stars / 3, with a floor of 0.3, so that no active pollster gets zero weight. The table records each assignment and its reason.

Pollster	Stars	Why

Emerson College	2.9	Strong track record, transparent methods, member of transparency ecosystem; among the most accurate primary pollsters.
YouGov (incl. Yahoo, BGSU)	2.9	Large panels, disclosed methodology, long accuracy record across cycles.
Echelon Insights	2.8	High transparency, consistent methodology, publishes full crosstabs.
AtlasIntel	2.7	Excellent 2020-2024 accuracy; strong POLLSCORE analogue, though its all-adult samples get a population discount.
JL Partners / Daily Mail	2.0	Competent newer firm; media-sponsored; moderate transparency.
Focaldata, Noble Predictive, Verasight	2.0	Modern online-panel shops with reasonable disclosure but shorter records.
I&I/TIPP	1.8	Long record, mixed accuracy, moderate transparency.
Harvard-Harris, Big Data Poll, Rasmussen, Overton, Lake Research, Yale Youth, Quantus	1.5	Either persistent house lean, partisan clientele, unusual samples, or thin disclosure. Harvard-Harris shows a very large pro-Harris house effect; Lake is a Democratic firm.
Public Sentiment Institute	1.0	Tiny samples, little methodological disclosure.
McLaughlin & Associates, Zogby	0.5	Documented histories of large errors and partisan work; 538's lowest tiers. Included with minimal weight rather than excluded, so exclusion judgment calls cannot steer the average.

Two principles govern the table. First, disclosure earns credibility as much as accuracy. A firm that shows its weighting targets and crosstabs can be audited, and 538 finds that such firms have lower future error. Second, partisan clientele costs weight. Partisan pollsters do not lie, but firms that do more than ten percent partisan work carry higher error and bias.

4. Credibility of the individual poll

Within a firm's output, each poll earns weight from four terms. The terms multiply:

- Recency. The weight decays 3 percent per day of age. 538 uses about 7 percent per day near election day. Two years before the primaries, the news moves slowly, so a steeper decay would tie the average to whichever firm polled last. A 30-day-old poll keeps about 40 percent of full weight.
- Sample size. The weight scales with the square root of the sample. It caps at 5,000 respondents, which is 538's cap. Information grows with the root of n, and one 25,000-person poll must not become the whole average.
- Population. A likely-voter sample gets full weight. A registered-voter sample gets 0.9. An all-adult sample gets 0.75. This is 538's population preference, written as a continuous weight. Primary electorates are small and differ from adults in general.
- Pollster credibility. This is the star weight from Section 3.

The final weight is the product of the four terms. For example, AtlasIntel's May 2026 poll (n = 2,069, all adults, 2.7 stars, about 70 days old) carries weight 0.12 times 1.86 times 0.75 times 0.90, which is 0.15. A fresh Echelon likely-voter poll carries about 0.60. Recency dominates, as intended.

5. House effects

Pollsters have habits. Harvard-Harris shows Kamala Harris 10 to 20 points above the field average. AtlasIntel runs high on Buttigieg and Ocasio-Cortez. Before it averages, the desk computes each firm's mean deviation from the unadjusted average, per candidate, across all its polls. It then subtracts half of that deviation. This is the half-correction that 538 describes. It uses half, not all, because a steady deviation can be a house lean or a real methodological insight. A full correction would assume the crowd is always right. A zero correction would let one loud firm drag the average. The desk leaves single-poll firms uncorrected, because one poll cannot separate lean from noise.

6. Validation

The test of a homemade average is agreement with professional aggregators that use richer methods. In mid-July 2026, the desk's average has Harris at 28.6 percent. RealClearPolling has 28.9, 270toWin has 29.6, Race to the WH has 29.5, and VoteHub has 28.2. For Newsom, the desk has 16.5 and the others have 16.5 to 16.8. For Buttigieg, the desk has about 12.4 and the others have 12.2 to 13.0. For AOC, the desk has about 10.3 and the others have 9.3 to 11.1. The desk's engine sits inside the professional spread for every major candidate.

7. Polls are not probabilities

A 29 percent poll share two years out is not a 29 percent nomination probability. Early national primary polls mostly measure name recognition. Consider the early national leaders about two years before past primaries. Lieberman in 2004, Clinton in 2008, Giuliani in 2008, and Jeb Bush in 2016 all led and lost. Romney in 2012, Clinton in 2016, Biden in 2020, and Trump in 2024 all led and won. The early leader wins about half the time. A non-leader with a real path wins more often than the share implies; Obama trailed Clinton by about 20 points in 2006. 538's primary models handled this by adding endorsements and fundamentals to the polls. The desk handles it a different way. It does not read shares as probabilities, and it uses the market as the probability layer.

8. The edge: polls versus market

The desk's tradeable output is the gap between the weighted poll average and the prediction-market price. Read the July 2026 board as follows:

- Harris. Polls 29, market about 8 cents. The market treats her lead as name recognition only and pays about 11-to-1 against the polling leader. History says early leaders win about half the time; the market says 8 percent. Both cannot be true. This is the largest available fade of the market consensus.
- Ossoff. Polls about 2, market about 14 cents. The market prices an announcement that the polls cannot yet measure. Ossoff has said on the record

that he is not running. Any Ossoff position, including the desk's wedge, carries announcement risk that the polls will not warn you about.

- Buttigieg. Polls about 13, market about 5 cents. This is the largest gap in the polls' favor among plausible candidates. He leads several likely-voter polls outright. If the polling is signal, this is the value row on the board.
- Newsom. Polls about 17, market about 18 cents. The two agree. This is the control that shows the other gaps are real, not artifacts of the method.

Three rules govern the strategy. One: a divergence is information, not an automatic trade. The market has read the same polls, so trade only when you can name what the price misses. Two: size a divergence trade as a long shot. Use quarter-Kelly or less, stay within the theme cap, and use the Ossoff desk's calculator. Three: prefer trades where the polls and the structure agree against the price (Buttigieg) over trades that need the polls to be wrong in one direction (Ossoff).

9. Limitations

The desk does not model herding penalties. It does not bootstrap uncertainty intervals. It does not impute missing transparency data. Its star ratings are informed approximations of 538's published ratings, not reproductions. The desk updates the poll database when it adds new releases; it does not scrape automatically. The market prices on the page do refresh live. These are the honest costs of a one-page engine. None of them move the average outside the professional spread today.

10. Sources

- G. Elliott Morris, 'How 538's pollster ratings work', ABC News/538, January 2024.
- 538, 'How our polling averages work' (exponential decay, sample-size weighting, house-effect correction).
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- Nate Silver, 'So how did the polls do in 2024?', Silver Bulletin (primary polls among the most accurate categories; about 4-point average general-election bias).
- Wikipedia, 'Nationwide opinion polling for the 2028 Democratic Party presidential primaries' (poll database; 270toWin, RealClearPolling, Race to the WH, VoteHub aggregates).
- The Hill and Newsweek reporting, July 2026 (Emerson poll; prediction-market moves; Ossoff's CNN statement that he is not running).